

So this project is called East Meets Feed. It started pretty informally — my girlfriend Yujia is a lifestyle and fashion creator, and I kept noticing that her content was genuinely good but nothing was really happening with it. We talked about it, and I said, let me just run this properly.

So I took it on as a solo project — account activation across Instagram, Douyin, and Xiaohongshu simultaneously. I came in as her strategist, activator, and producer. No budget, no paid promotion. Just strategy and content.

What I want to walk you through today is how I thought about it, what I actually did, and what the numbers looked like at the end.

Yujia is a data engineer by profession, but she has a real eye for photography. The kind of content she puts out — golden-hour portraits, curated fits, New York cultural spaces — it stops people mid-scroll. The quality was already there.

What wasn't there was any system. She had over 2,900 combined followers across three platforms and hadn't posted consistently on any of them. No cross-posting, no caption strategy, no posting cadence. The accounts were just sitting.

From a marketer's standpoint, that's actually an interesting starting position. You have an audience that's already opted in, content that's already strong, and zero infrastructure around it. The ceiling is high and the lift is mostly operational.

That's what made me want to take this on. I knew if we just got organized and intentional about it, the results would follow pretty quickly.

The first thing I had to figure out was how to treat three very different platforms without creating three separate full-time jobs. The answer was platform adaptation, not platform duplication.

Instagram is her Western-facing channel. English-speaking audience, NYC creatives, lifestyle community. The content there leans editorial — polished photography, thoughtful captions, aspirational but not out of reach.

Douyin is a completely different beast. The algorithm there rewards emotional resonance above everything else. It doesn't matter how beautiful the visuals are — if the caption doesn't create an emotional reaction, it won't travel. So on Douyin, the writing had to do the heavy lifting. Poetic, introspective, in Chinese.

Xiaohongshu sits somewhere in between. It's lifestyle discovery for Chinese women — outfits, locations, aspiration. The content strategy there was to cross-distribute from what we were already shooting for Instagram, with localized framing.

One shoot. Three platforms. Three different stories told to three different audiences. That's the efficiency play.

Phase one was deliberately simple. Two content pillars: strong visuals and resonant copy. No complicated frameworks, no elaborate calendars. Just those two things done well.

On the visual side — iconic locations, fashion-forward, editorial feel. The Met Museum, Central Park. Places that carry context on their own before you even write a word.

On the copy side — I wasn't writing descriptive captions. Either the caption invites an emotional response or it asks something that pulls the audience into conversation. That's it.

One deliberate call I made: no hashtags. I'd seen data from her previous posts that hashtags weren't moving the needle for this account. So I stripped them out entirely and treated Phase one as a clean test — does the content perform on its own merit? That question mattered to me.

Everything was organic. No boosts, no promotions. I wanted to know what we were actually working with before putting any money behind it.

Before I show you results, here's where we started — Day zero.

Instagram had 2,387 followers and 22 interactions in the previous 30 days. The account existed, people were there, but there was basically no activity happening.

Xiaohongshu had 530 fans and 1,892 lifetime likes and saves. Decent numbers, but the last post was weeks old. The audience was still there — they just hadn't been given anything new to respond to.

Douyin had 13 fans and 100 total likes. Nearly empty. On an algorithm-driven platform, that's not necessarily a disadvantage — there's no bad history to overcome.

I'm showing you this because the before picture makes the after picture mean something.

In under one week of active posting, here's what happened.

Instagram interactions went from 22 to 207 per 30 days. Views climbed from 14,400 to 21,700. Follower count dropped by 9 — those were ghost accounts the algorithm cleaned out. I'd rather have a smaller, cleaner audience than inflated numbers.

Xiaohongshu grew from 530 to 556 fans. Likes and saves went from 1,892 to 1,964. The top post pulled 1,130 views with a 6.2% interaction rate, which is well above platform average.

Douyin was the standout. Fans went from 13 to 258. Likes went from 100 to 1,566. We put out 8 new posts, and the first one became the hero of the whole campaign.

Total valid KPIs — likes, comments, shares, saves, new followers across all three platforms — came in at 2,191. The target was 500. We hit 4.4 times that, in under a week, with no paid spend whatsoever.

Two posts drove the majority of results, and both of them validate the strategy in different ways.

On Douyin, the top post was titled 'I Feel Deeply, But Struggle to Express.' Short video, everyday aesthetic, and a caption that just resonated. 24,000 plays in under 48 hours. 736 likes, 49 shares, 68 saves, 155 new followers from one post. The platform even issued a traffic reward for the engagement signal — 307 yuan worth of algorithmic boost. That's the platform telling you that your content is working.

On Instagram, the hero was the Met Museum shoot. Right location, right styling, right light. 110 likes, 12 comments, 2,700 views, 141 profile visits. Highest engagement rate of the campaign.

And here's what I was most pleased about: that same Met shoot became the top post on Xiaohongshu simultaneously. I didn't shoot separate content for that platform. I reframed what we already had. One creative execution, best performer on two platforms at the same time.

I want to be straightforward about where this fell short, because that's where the actual learning is.

Douyin reach dropped off hard after the first post. Post one hit 24,000 plays. Posts two and three came in at 3,400 and 1,500. The algorithm responded to the emotional hook once, but I hadn't built a repeatable brief that could consistently recreate that signal. That's a content strategy gap, not a platform problem.

Xiaohongshu had a similar pattern. The Met post performed well — 1,130 views, strong engagement. Posts two and three dropped to 144 and 201 views. The issue was discovery. Without topic tags, Xiaohongshu's search-based feed just didn't surface the content.

Which brings me to the no-hashtag decision. I still think it was right for Douyin. But Xiaohongshu is fundamentally a tag-discovery platform. Content quality alone doesn't override that. I overcorrected by applying the same rule to a platform with different mechanics.

Phase two fix: tighter emotional brief for Douyin, topic hashtags on every Xiaohongshu post, and keep pushing the cultural location shoots on Instagram.



The assignment asked for 500 valid KPI interactions across the campaign.

We came in at 2,191. Under one week. No paid promotion.

Douyin drove 86% of that total — 1,888 KPIs. Instagram added 201. Xiaohongshu contributed 102. Every platform moved forward from where it started.

I think what this shows is that when you have the right content strategy and you execute it cleanly, you don't need a budget to get results. The content does the work. 4.4 times the target isn't luck — it's a repeatable process.

Four things I'm taking forward from this.

First — on Chinese platforms, the caption is the product. Douyin's top post won because of six words in the caption. The visuals mattered, but the emotion is what the algorithm amplified. Write for feeling, not for description.

Second — one shoot can serve three audiences if you know how to frame it differently for each platform. That's not laziness, that's leverage. The Met shoot being number one on both Instagram and Xiaohongshu from the same assets proved that.

Third — organic content quality is a real growth lever. Nothing here was boosted or promoted. 2,191 KPIs came entirely from posting the right thing in the right way. That's a strong foundation to build paid strategy on top of later.

Fourth — platform mechanics are not interchangeable. The same playbook doesn't port directly across platforms. Douyin is algorithm-first. Xiaohongshu is tag-discovery-first. You have to understand how each platform distributes content before you can optimize for it.

Phase two starts with all of that in hand. The account is active, the audience is growing, and now we know what works and why. Thanks.